

Beer & Cask Ale - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

Cask Ale: Britain's Living Beer

Beer may be the oldest drink humanity ever made on purpose. In a cave near Haifa, archaeologists found traces of brewing about thirteen thousand years old, from before farming, before the wheel, before writing. Some scholars even argue we settled down and planted the first fields of grain partly to keep the beer coming, which would make beer not a by-product of civilisation but one of its causes. Four thousand years ago the Sumerians were singing a hymn to Ninkasi, their goddess of brewing, and the hymn doubles as a recipe. Wherever people grew grain, beer followed, from Egypt to China to the muddy villages of Bronze Age Britain.

So beer is everywhere, and almost everywhere it is now made the same industrial way, filtered, pasteurised, fizzed up with gas, sealed in a can. Dead, in the kindest possible sense. But you have landed in the one country that never quite let the old way die. It is called cask ale, or real ale, and it is beer that arrives at the pub still alive, still quietly fermenting in its barrel in the cellar below the bar, finished not by a factory but by the publican, and pulled up to your glass with a long hand-worked lever. No other country on earth serves its national beer this way as a matter of course. It is one of Britain's great unsung traditions, hiding in plain sight on every proper pub counter.

The clue to look for is a row of tall handles standing on the bar like oars. Over the next few stories I'll tell you how beer is made at all, what makes cask ale different and why it nearly vanished, why Edinburgh was once as famous for beer as for whisky, how to read a pub like a local, and how British beer went out and conquered the world. Then you can go and find a living pint yourself.

How Beer Is Made

Beer is made from four things, and you already know all of them. Barley, water, hops, and yeast. Three of those you met in the whisky story. The fourth, the hop, is beer's own signature, and we'll get to it.

Think of beer as bread's liquid cousin. Same grain, same yeast, same warm smell while it's being made. A baker and a brewer are running the same experiment in different directions, and for most of history they worked side by side, often in the same household, often the same woman doing both.

It starts with malt, which is barley that has been soaked, allowed to begin sprouting, and then dried, so the grain unlocks its own sugars. The brewer grinds this malt and steeps it in hot water in a big vessel called a mash tun, essentially making an enormous pot of sweet barley tea. What runs off is called the wort, and it is warm, cloudy, and sweet enough to drink like a dessert. Brewers do taste it, and visitors on brewery tours are often handed a cup. It tastes like the milk at the bottom of a bowl of breakfast cereal.

Then comes the boil, and the hops go in. A hop is the flower of a climbing vine, a soft green cone that looks like a tiny pinecone made of paper. On its own it is shockingly bitter, and that is the point. The bitterness balances all that malt sweetness, the way lemon balances sugar, and the resins in the hop also help keep the beer from spoiling. Hops came late to Britain, only catching on in the fourteen and fifteen

hundreds, and for a while the unhopped old drink was called ale and the newfangled hopped stuff was called beer.

After the boil, the wort is cooled and the yeast is pitched in, and the real magic starts. Yeast is a living single-celled fungus that eats sugar and gives out two things, alcohol and carbon dioxide. In a bakery you keep the gas and drive off the alcohol, and you get risen bread. In a brewery you keep both, and you get beer. For a few days the vats seethe with a thick cap of foam, and a working brewhouse smells warm and yeasty and faintly of toast.

And here is the family secret worth exactly one sentence. If you take that fermented liquid before any hops have touched it and run it twice through a copper still, you are on the road to whisky, which is why brewers like to say, with a straight face, that whisky is simply beer that went on to further education.

What comes out of the fermenting vessel is, in most of the world, then filtered bright, pasteurised so nothing lives in it, carbonated with injected gas, and sealed up. Stable, consistent, and finished. But in Britain there has always been another path out of the brewery, the one where the beer leaves home still alive. That path leads down into a pub cellar, and it's where we're going next.

The Living Pint, and the Four Friends Who Saved It

Cask ale is beer that leaves the brewery unfinished on purpose. It is racked into a metal cask with its yeast still in it, neither filtered nor pasteurised, and sent to the pub still working. Down in the cellar it completes a slow second fermentation, building a gentle natural sparkle, nothing like the aggressive fizz of gassed beer. The pub isn't just selling this beer. The pub is raising it.

That job belongs to the cellarman, and it is a real craft. The cask is set on its side on a rack and left to settle. A porous wooden peg called a spile is knocked into it to let the fermentation breathe, then swapped for a hard one when the condition is right. The cellar is kept at cellar temperature, around eleven to thirteen degrees Celsius, the low fifties Fahrenheit. Cool, in other words. The old joke that the British drink warm beer is wrong. They drink cool beer, served at the temperature where its flavour actually opens up, rather than ice cold, which is the temperature at which you can't taste anything.

Once the cask is tapped, the clock runs. Air comes in as beer goes out, and in a few days the beer is past its best. Cask ale must be sold fresh and looked after daily, like bread. In simple country pubs it is poured by gravity, straight from a tap in the cask. Most pubs use the beer engine instead, the tall hand pump on the bar. Each long pull of that lever draws a quarter pint up from the cellar by suction. The engineer Joseph Bramah patented the classic design in 1797, and it has barely needed to change since. No gas pressure touches the beer at any point. When you see someone pulling a pint in three slow strokes, you are watching a machine from the age of Napoleon doing exactly what it was built for.

All of this nearly disappeared. After the Second World War, Britain's brewers consolidated into a handful of giants, and the giants preferred keg beer, filtered, pasteurised, pushed to the tap with carbon dioxide. Dead beer keeps for months and needs no craft in the cellar, so pub by pub, the handles came off the bars.

Then, in March 1971, four young men from the north-west of England, Michael Hardman, Graham Lees, Jim Makin and Bill Mellor, went on holiday to the west of Ireland. In Kruger's bar in the village of Dunquin, in County Kerry, grumbling over their pints about how dismal British beer had become, they decided, half as a joke, to found a protest movement. They called it the Campaign for the Revitalisation of Ale, soon renamed the Campaign for Real Ale, CAMRA for short. It struck a nerve nobody knew was there. Within a few years it had tens of thousands of members, a bestselling Good Beer Guide, and festivals up and down the country, and the big brewers were scrambling to put the hand pumps back. It is regularly called the most successful consumer campaign in Europe, and it is why the living pint still exists for you to order tonight. Four friends in a bar, annoyed enough to do something. Worth remembering.

Edinburgh, Brewing City

Everyone knows Edinburgh and whisky. Almost nobody remembers that for two centuries this was one of the great brewing cities of the world, and that the whole town used to smell of it, a warm, sweet, toasty fog of malt drifting over the rooftops that older residents still recall with real affection.

It began with monks. When King David the First founded Holyrood Abbey in the eleven hundreds, the canons did what monastic orders did everywhere in Europe and set up a brewhouse, helped by something they may not have fully understood. Edinburgh sits on a seam of underground water, wells fed through old sandstone, and that water comes up hard, loaded with minerals, which happens to be superb for brewing pale, clean-tasting ales. Brewers later mapped where the good wells ran, a band curving from Holyrood out through Fountainbridge, and called it the charmed circle. Breweries crowded onto that line like houses along a good street.

By the mid eighteen hundreds Edinburgh had around forty breweries, and only London and Burton upon Trent rivalled it in Britain. Two names towered over the rest. William Younger's, founded in 1749 and eventually brewing in the shadow of Holyrood Abbey itself, and William McEwan's, founded in 1856 at Fountainbridge. Both became export empires, shipping strong Scotch ale to Canada, the Caribbean, India and Australia. The two firms merged in 1931, and through later mergers became the core of Scottish and Newcastle, for a time one of the biggest brewers on the planet.

Scottish beer even had its own private language. From the mid eighteen hundreds, beers here were named after the wholesale price of a cask, in shillings. A modest everyday beer might cost sixty shillings a hogshead, a stronger one seventy, a stronger one still eighty, and the names stuck to the beers themselves. In an Edinburgh pub you can still order an eighty shilling, pronounced eighty bob, and get a smooth, malty dark amber ale, essentially a beer named after a Victorian invoice. At the top of the scale sat the strong, treacly Scotch ale that export markets loved, affectionately called a wee heavy. And Scottish ales as a family lean maltier and less bitter than English ones, partly plain geography, since hops never grew happily this far north and every sack of them had to be carted up from England at real expense, so brewers used them sparingly and let the malt do the talking.

The twentieth century took it all apart. Takeovers, closures, demolitions, until by the two thousands a city of forty breweries was down to one grand old survivor, the Caledonian on Slateford Road, founded in 1869. The Caledonian was a working Victorian time capsule, brewing in open-topped coppers heated by direct flame, the last brewery in Britain doing it that way. It should have had a happy ending, but it didn't. Heineken, who had inherited it, announced its closure in 2022, saying the Victorian kit was no longer economical, and the site is being turned into housing. A hundred and fifty three years of continuous brewing, ended by a spreadsheet.

And yet the story isn't over. A new generation of small breweries has sprung up in and around the city, and the beer they make is often exactly what the Victorians would recognise, pale ales and eighty shillings pulled through hand pumps. Edinburgh's beer, like its whisky, refuses to stay buried.

How to Read a Pub

The word pub is short for public house, and that is the whole idea in two words. Historically it was literally somebody's house, with the front room opened to the public, the keeper living upstairs, and the beer often brewed out the back. That is why a good pub still feels like a home rather than a shop, with its fireplace and its dog and its regulars in their usual corner, and why the person in charge is called the landlord or landlady.

The signs came from illiteracy. In the thirteen nineties, English law required alehouses to hang out a sign so the authorities could identify them, and since most customers couldn't read, the signs were pictures. A

red lion, a white hart, a coach and horses, a king's head. Centuries later the pictures remain, swinging over the street, and once you start decoding them you can't stop. A Red Lion is usually old royal or noble heraldry. A Bishop's or King's anything points to an old landowner. A name like the Volunteer Arms remembers a local regiment.

The etiquette is simple but real. You order at the bar, you pay when you order, and nobody will ever come to your table, which baffles visitors who sit politely waiting for service that will never arrive. If you're in company, you buy rounds, each person taking a turn to fetch drinks for the table, and keeping honest track of whose turn it is matters more than money in Britain. And pubs are far more family-friendly than their reputation abroad suggests. At lunchtime and early evening, a decent pub is full of families eating fish and chips or a Sunday roast, kids with a lemonade or a ginger beer, dogs asleep by the fire. It is closer to a living room with a licence than to a bar.

Edinburgh has some of the finest pub interiors in Britain, and three are worth crossing town for. The Cafe Royal, tucked behind Princes Street, is a Victorian jewel box, with a great oval island bar, a compartmented ceiling, and six large Doulton tile murals of famous inventors, Watt, Faraday, Franklin, Caxton, Stephenson and Peel, made for an exhibition in 1886. Its oyster bar next door glows with stained-glass sportsmen. Around the corner, the Guildford Arms of 1896 hides one of the most extravagant painted ceilings you'll ever see in a room where people are drinking beer, run by the same family since it opened. The Bow Bar in Victoria Street you've already heard about in the whisky story, and its row of hand pumps is as good as its gantry.

But the one to plan around is the Sheep Heid Inn, in Duddingston village on the far side of Arthur's Seat, which you're climbing in a few days. The story goes there's been an inn on the spot since 1360, which would make it one of the oldest pubs in Scotland, though the building you'll actually sit in is mostly eighteenth century, so treat the date as legend with a good pedigree. Legend also says King James the Sixth stopped in often and once gifted the landlord a snuff box made from a ram's head. What is certainly real is the skittle alley out the back, built in the eighteen eighties and said to be the oldest surviving in Scotland, two ancient wooden lanes where you can bowl at pins while your lunch is cooked. Come down off the summit, walk into Duddingston, and you'll have earned it.

Beer's Greatest Journeys

Every beer style is a souvenir of a journey, and the most famous journey of all is the one to India. The romantic version goes like this. British beer spoiled on the six-month sail around Africa, so a clever London brewer named George Hodgson invented a new beer, loaded with extra hops and extra strength to survive the voyage, and India Pale Ale was born. It is a lovely story, and beer historians have taken it apart almost line by line. Hodgson's Bow Brewery, from the seventeen eighties, really did dominate the India trade, but mostly because it sat conveniently close to the East India Company's docks and offered the ships' officers generous credit. The beer he sent was October ale, a strong, heavily hopped pale beer the English had already been brewing for a century, which simply happened to travel magnificently. Nothing was invented for India, and plenty of ordinary porter made the same voyage in the same holds and arrived just fine. What India provided was a market, and eventually a name. So tell the legend if you like, but tell it as a legend.

When Hodgson got greedy and tried to cut out the middlemen, the East India traders took their business to Burton upon Trent, where the gypsum-rich water turned out to make pale bitter beer better than anywhere on earth, and Burton became the beer capital of the Empire. Edinburgh's brewers piled into the same trade, and by Victorian times Younger's and McEwan's ales were drunk from Bombay to Melbourne to San Francisco. The other great British export was the dark family, porter and stout, born in eighteenth-century London as the drink of the porters who hauled the city's goods, brewed black and roasty, and perfected across the Irish Sea in Dublin, where a brewer named Guinness bet everything on it.

Then the world changed teams. In Bavaria, brewers had long stored their beer through the summer in cold caves, and in that cold a different yeast slowly took over, one that ferments at low temperatures and drops to the bottom of the vat, giving a cleaner, crisper beer. Lager, from the German word for storeroom. In 1842 the Bohemian town of Pilsen hired a Bavarian brewer named Josef Groll, who combined that cold fermentation with very pale malt and soft local water, and produced the first golden lager the world had seen. In an age of new clear glassware, a sparkling gold beer was irresistible, and pilsner-style lager went on to conquer essentially the entire planet. Ninety-something percent of all beer drunk on earth today is its descendant.

Britain held out, kept its hand pumps and its living ale, and by the late twentieth century that made it a museum. Luckily. American homebrewers and small craft brewers, in revolt against bland industrial lager, went looking for flavour, found the old British styles, and rebuilt them with turbocharged American hops. The modern IPA, the flagship of the craft beer movement, is a British colonial export re-imported home, louder and pushier than it left. Scotland joined the wave with gusto, from a swaggering brewery up in Aberdeenshire that became a global brand to dozens of small outfits around Edinburgh quietly filling casks again.

Which brings you back to the bar, and the row of tall handles. Beer has sailed to India, gone underground in Bavaria, turned gold in Bohemia, and circled the planet in cans. After all that, the rarest thing you can order anywhere in the world of beer is the simplest thing on offer here, a pint that an hour ago was still quietly alive in the cool dark under your feet. Order that one.